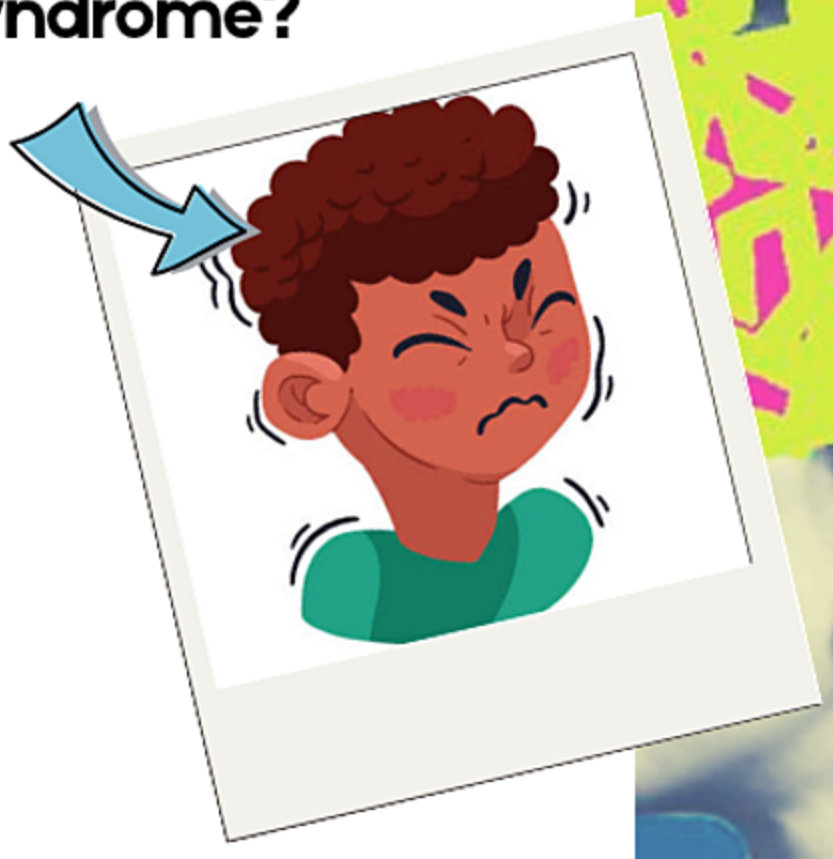

WHAT IS
TOURETTE
SYNDROME?

Notes

What is Tourette Syndrome?

Tourette (too-RET) syndrome is a disorder that involves repetitive movements or unwanted sounds (tics) that can't be easily controlled. For instance, you might repeatedly blink your eyes, shrug your shoulders or blurt out unusual sounds or offensive words.



MESSAGES now

Fun Fact:

Tics typically show up between ages 2 and 15, with the average being around 6 years of age. Males are about three to four times more likely than females to develop Tourette syndrome.



Notes

What are its symptoms?

Tics – sudden, brief, intermittent movements or sounds – are the hallmark sign of Tourette syndrome. They can range from mild to severe. Severe symptoms might significantly interfere with communication, daily functioning and quality of life.



Tics are classified as:

- Simple tics. These sudden, brief and repetitive tics involve a limited number of muscle groups.
- Complex tics. These distinct, coordinated patterns of movements involve several muscle groups.



Notes

Forms of Treatment:

Although there's no cure for Tourette syndrome, treatments are available such as behavioral therapy and medications. Many people with Tourette syndrome don't need treatment when symptoms aren't troublesome. Tics often lessen or become controlled after the teen years.



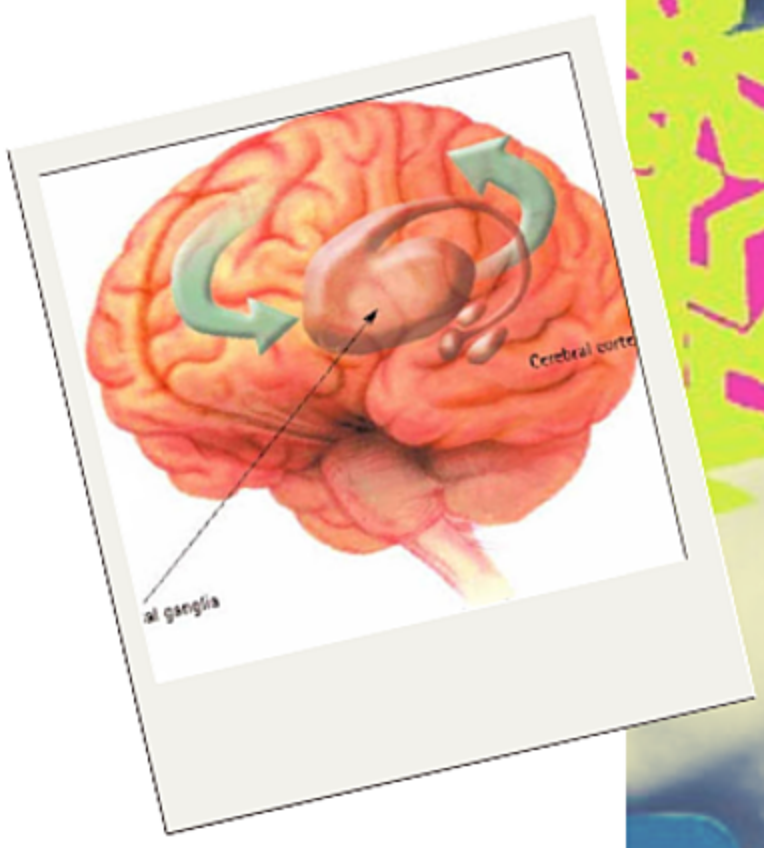




Notes

Causes:

The exact cause of Tourette syndrome isn't known. It's a complex disorder likely caused by a combination of inherited (genetic) and environmental factors. Chemicals in the brain that transmit nerve impulses (neurotransmitters), including dopamine and serotonin, might play a role.





Notes

Risk factors:

Risk factors for Tourette syndrome include:

- Family history.Having a family history of Tourette syndrome or other tic disorders might increase the risk of developing Tourette syndrome.
- Sex. Males are about three to four times more likely than females to develop Tourette syndrome.



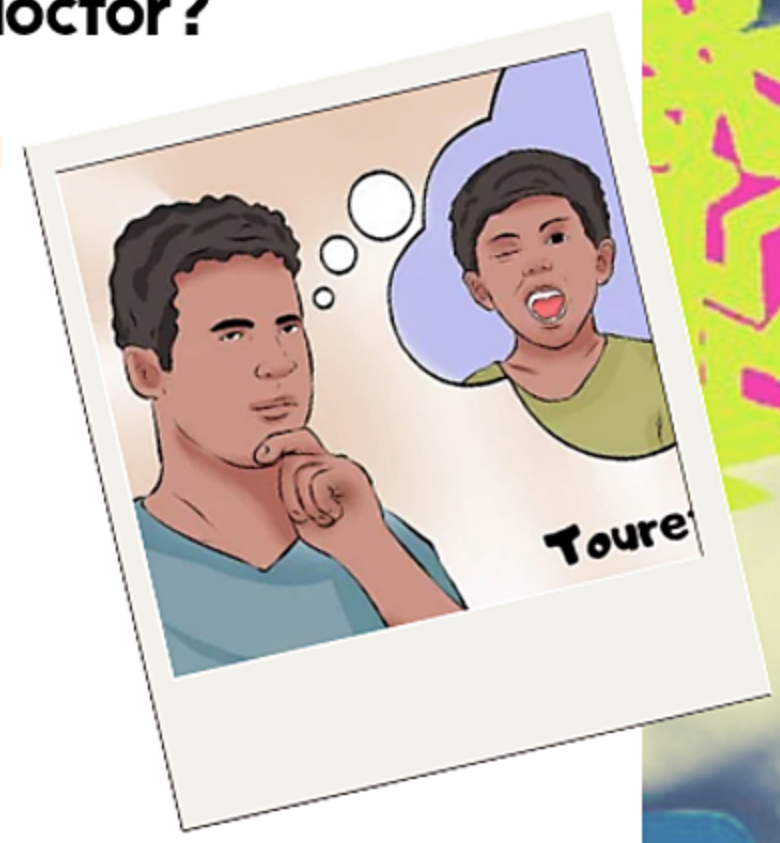






Notes

When to see a doctor?



See your child's pediatrician if you notice your child displaying involuntary movements or sounds.

Not all tics indicate Tourette syndrome. Many children develop tics that go away on their own after a few weeks or months. But whenever a child shows unusual behavior, it's important to identify the cause and rule out serious health problems.



